

Assignment 2 Part 1 Heritage Sites – Essay Outline
Deserted Industry to Minimalistic Hotel: Adaptive Reuse of The Dexamenes Winery

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Architectural Conservation Philosophy and Ethics ARCH 4200

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I selected the Dexamenes Seaside Hotel in Greece by K-Studio as my adaptive reuse case study because of my opportunity to visit Greece with my family a couple years ago. During my time there I learned a lot and experienced the amazing hospitality and resilience of the Greek people, even during challenging economic times. I stayed and visited multiple different reuse hotels and restaurants. Seeing firsthand how local ingenuity was used to give historic structure new life, while of course honoring their long and storied history. Unfortunately, the specific sites I visited lacked sufficient online information for this essay. Fortunately, the Dexamenes Seaside Hotel, although being more luxurious than the places I experienced is a powerful story and example. Born from economic crisis and industrial failure to become an interesting minimalist architectural destination, I like how the site was transformed with respect for its history and culture while maintaining social ties to the local community.

Original Use: Industry scale winery and distillery for black Corinth currants

Adaptive Reuse: Seaside hotel, smaller event space and restaurant connected

Project Background:

- History of the Site – Starts with the “Currants' Crisis” in the 1910’s
- In response The Autonomous Currants Organization builds the Dexamenes winery on Kourouta beach (for efficient maritime shipping), along the southeastern coast of the Greek mainland around 1920
- Ceased operations and falls out of use completely in the early 1980’s
- Abandoned structure bought in 2003 by Dexamenes Seaside Hotel, renovation with K-Studio architecture firm starts in 2013 and construction finishes in 2019

Cultural Landscape:

- Coastal landscape of the Kourouta beach and the surrounding waterfront area
- Historic industrial roots, relationship between environment and human activity
- Impact of original structure
- Impact of reuse, shift to tourism, industry to recreation

Heritage Values:

- Tangible – Brutalist large wine concrete tanks, raw industrial structures/framework, interaction with the beach/water
- Intangible – Greek industrial and agricultural history, country wide economic hardships (Currants' Crisis and ongoing modern financial shortcomings), local employment

Character-Defining Elements:

- Raw Industrial materials
- Large concrete wine tanks
- Large metal drums
- Functional/utilitarian aesthetic
- Simplicity, leaving decay/remnants of history

Conservation/Design Philosophy:

- Minimal intervention, “piercing” existing structure with new elements
- Respect for the history and industry of before

- Age-value, preserving/using patina and signs of decay - Alois Riegl
- New additions distinguished - Venice Charter

Impact of New Interventions:

- Modern materials (steel, timber, engineered glass) distinguish from original's while fitting into overall feel and simplicity
- Lightweight structural reinforcement – helps maintain and preserve
- Landscaping, beachfront changes augment site – more accessible, enjoyable

Standards and Guidelines for Conservation:

- Standard 1 - Conserves heritage value of a historic place – project centers on respecting and utilizing abandoned industrial site for modern reuse
- Standard 2 - Conserves the character-defining elements of a historic place – Reuses concrete tanks, other elements – conserved/adapted without significant alteration

Challenges to Conservation Standards:

- Expensive, could price out local and Greek shareholders
- Luxury hotel on failed industry (significant contrast in use)
- Could be understandable given need for commercial viability, saving abandoned structures

Standard 11 – New Additions:

- “Should be physically and visually compatible with, subordinate to, and distinguishable from the historic place...” – accomplished with modern simple, distinguishable materials

- Other additions – distinctly modern while adhering to original spirit of site – example:
restaurant pavilion, subordinate in height to main concrete structure w/ modern materials

Suitability of New Use:

- Hotel – relatively appropriate/compatible reuse, I personally like the contrast of use while maintaining original aesthetic
- Suitable – local employment, economic survival, access, layout of hotel rooms directly uses/informed by original use, function linked to form

Sustainability Aspects:

- The most sustainable building is the one already built - Carl Elefante
- Adaptive reuse, preservation of embodied carbon of large concrete structure
- Social and cultural preservation of local history, providing local employment again
- “mostly” local materials
- Minimal environmental waste, generally green conscious

Ethical Considerations:

- Site transformation from economic hardship/failing industry to luxury hotel
- Cultural gentrification or responsible revitalization
- Ethical decisions made throughout – Greek ownership, saving abandoned buildings, local economic opportunities, historic preservation

Sources:

<https://k-studio.gr/project/dexamenes/>

<https://www.archdaily.com/939385/dexamenes-seaside-hotel-k-studio>

<https://www.designboom.com/architecture/k-studio-dexamenes-seaside-hotel-greece-02-09-19/>

<https://www.historicplaces.ca/media/18072/81468-parks-s+g-eng-web2.pdf>

https://www.researchgate.net/publication/265833292_The_Greenest_Building_Is_One_That_Is_Already_Built

Images: From main website (photographer unknown) - <https://dexamenes.com/>



